

mcx

A Typst package for typesetting randomized multiple-choice exams.

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1. Introduction

The `mcx` package is a Typst implementation inspired by the LaTeX package `mcexam`. It allows educators to create randomized, multiple-version exams with automated answer keys, solution guides, and diagnostic tables. It also provides features for generating Python scripts to automate the exam generation process. `mcx` is inspired by LaTeX package `mcexam`, but is designed to be more flexible when user wants to insert code snippets or other content, leveraging Typst's powerful typesetting capabilities.

1.1. Features

- **Randomized Exams:** Create multiple versions of an exam with randomized question order and/or answer choices using a single seed value.
- **Flexible Shuffling:** Randomize question blocks (respecting connectivity logic) and answer choices.
- **Multiple Output Modes:** Seamlessly switch between student exams, answer keys, solution manuals, and exam generation concept overviews.
- **Automated Tables:** Generate question and answer permutation tables to track how content moved between versions.
- **PDF Splitting:** Includes a helper script to automatically split a single compiled PDF into individual version files.

2. Getting Started

To get started with `mcx`, you can import the package into your Typst document:

```
#import "@preview/mcx:0.4.0": *
```

3. Defining Question List

Use the provided macros to define your question list using the `mc-question` and `mc-answer` constructors:

```
#let my-questions = (
  mc-question(
    [...],
    (mc-answer(...), ...)
  ),
  ...
)
```

To build the exam using the defined question list, use the `mc-questions` function:

```
#mc-questions(my-questions, output: "exam", number-of-versions: 4, version: 1, seed: 40)
```

The `mc-questions` function takes the question list and generates the specified output based on the provided parameters:

- **output:** Specify the type of output to generate:
 - "exam": Generates the student version of the exam with questions and answer choices.
 - "answers": Generates exam with the correct answers.
 - "key": Generates the answer key table for the versions of the exam.
 - "concept": Generates a concept overview that explains the underlying logic when shuffling questions and answers, which can be useful for educators to understand the randomization process.

- **number-of-versions**: The number of different versions of the exam to generate. It will generate four versions by default.
- **version**: Specify a particular version to generate, and add the version number to the top of the file. It will generate the first version by default.
- **seed**: A number used to initialize the randomization process. Using the same seed will produce the same randomization, allowing for reproducibility. If not specified, it will default to 1. The randomization process is based on Typst package [suiji](#).
- **randomize-questions**: A boolean parameter that controls whether the order of questions should be randomized. If set to `true`, the questions will be shuffled based on the specified seed. If set to `false`, the questions will appear in the order they are defined in the source code across all versions. By default, this parameter is set to `true`.
 - The questions grouped together by the `follow` parameter in `mc-question` will be treated as a single block when `randomize-questions` is enabled, meaning that the entire block will be shuffled together while maintaining the internal order of questions within the block. This allows for maintaining logical connections between questions while still randomizing their order in the exam [Section 4](#).
- **randomize-answers**: Same as `randomize-questions` but for answer choices.
- **style**: A dictionary allowing users to customize the appearance of the output via predefined or custom styles. The available style options are:
 - **font** (string): Font family for the output, "Libertinus Serif" by default.
 - **font-size** (length): Base font size for the output, 11pt by default.
 - **v-numbering** (string): Numbering style for versions (e.g., "I", "1", "a"), "I" by default.
 - **q-numbering** (string): Question numbering style (e.g., "1, 2, 3", "a, b, c", "i, ii, iii"), "1" by default.
 - **a-numbering** (string): Answer choice numbering style (e.g., "A, B, C", "1, 2, 3", "a, b, c"), "A" by default.
 - **line-spacing** (length|float|int): Line spacing multiplier, 0.65em by default.
 - **margin** (dictionary (string, length)): Page margin size (e.g., `top : 1in`).
- **config**: Provide a custom boolean dictionary configuration for the output mode.
 - **show-header**: Display the heading at the top of the generated output.
 - **per-version-q-order**: Display the questions in the order they appear in each version or numerical order.
 - **show-q-perm-table**: Display the question permutation table.
 - **show-q-list**: Display the list of questions.
 - **show-correct**: Display the correct answers in the output.
 - **show-points**: Display the points for each question.
 - **show-explanation**: Display the explanations for each question.
 - **show-a-perm-table**: Display the answer permutation table.
 - **show-notes**: Display internal notes.
 - **show-key-table**: Display the answer key table.

4. Defining Question `mc-question`

```
#let qs = (
  mc-question(
    [
      What is  $2+2$ ?
    ],
    (
      mc-answer([ $4$ ], mark: "correct"),
      ...
    ),
  ),
```

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```
    permute: (type: "fixlastn", n: 2),
    instruction: [Some easy math question.],
    explanation: [Self-explanatory.],
  ),
  mc-question(
    [
      Given function:  $f(x) = x^3 - 2x^2 + 5x - 7$ , calculate  $f'(2)$ .
    ],
    (
      mc-answer([$9$], mark: "correct"),
      ...
    ),
    permute: "permuteall",
    follow: true,
    explanation: [Some explanation for this question.],
    notes: [This question is connected to the previous one, so it will be shuffled
  together with it when `randomize-questions` is enabled.],
  )
)
```

mc-question is the primary constructor for defining a multiple-choice question. It takes body which is a content block for the question text and an array of mc-answer for the answer choices. There are also optional parameters for controlling the permutation of questions and answers, as well as providing explanations and notes:

- q-breakable and a-breakable: These parameters allow you to specify whether the question content or individual answer choices can break across pages. This is useful for long questions or answer choices that may not fit on a single page. By default, both are set to false, meaning that the content will not break across pages.
- permute: Package will randomize the order of answers based on the specified permutation type. Details on the available permutation options for answers are provided in [Section 4.1](#).
- follow: The questions will be grouped together with the next follow questions, and the entire group will be permuted together based on the specified permute option. This allows for maintaining logical connections between questions while still randomizing their order in the exam.
- instruction: Provide an instruction that will be displayed at the beginning of the group of questions. This is useful for providing context or specific instructions related to the grouped questions.
- explanation and notes: These parameters allow you to provide additional content for each question that can be included in the solution manual or other output modes. The explanation is intended for detailed solutions, while notes can be used for any additional information or hints related to the question.

4.1. Permuting Answers

The permute parameter in mc-question allows you to specify how the answer choices should be randomized. The available options for permute are:

- "permuteall": Package will use the provided seed to randomize the order of answers for each version, resulting in different answer orders across versions.
- "fixlast": Similar to the "permuteall" option but keeping the last answer fixed in its position across versions.
- (type: "fixlastn", n): Similar to the "fixlast" option but keeping the last n answers fixed in their positions across versions. Will clamp n to [1, number of answers].

- "ordinal": The order of answers will either be the same as the order they are defined in the source code or reversed.
- "permutenone": The package will not randomize the order of answers, and they will appear in the same order across all versions.
- User can also specify a custom permutation function by passing an array of numbers representing the new order of answers. It can also be an array of arrays of numbers to specify different custom permutations for each version.

5. Defining Answer mc-answer

When defining answers for mc-question, mc-answer should be provided for each answer choice. The whole block of answers will be in an array as the parameter of mc-question. The mc-answer constructor takes the following parameters:

- body: The content block for the answer choice text.
- mark: An optional parameter to indicate if the answer is correct.
 - If set to "correct", the package will recognize this answer as the correct choice when generating answer keys and solution manuals. If not specified, the answer will be treated as incorrect by default.
 - It can also be set to a number to indicate the point value of the answer, which will be reflected in the solution manual and answer key outputs.

6. Data Flow Process

In case you are interested in understanding the internal workings of the mcx package, here is a high-level overview of the data flow process that occurs when you run the exam generation script:

- **Data Collection:** All objects created via mc-question are gathered into a single array.
- **First Layer Shuffling (Question Order):**
 - The system identifies questions marked with follow: true and bundles them with the preceding question into indivisible "blocks".
 - Subsequently, the order of these blocks is randomized based on the defined seed and the specific version number.
- **Second Layer Shuffling (Answer Order):**
 - The program iterates through each individual question and shuffles its internal answers array according to its specific permute attribute (e.g., permuteall, fixlast).
- **Mapping and Recording:**
 - The system automatically generates a mapping table to track the relationship between original and displayed positions (e.g., Question 1 in Version A corresponds to Question 5 in the source data; its Option A corresponds to original Option C).
 - This map is ultimately used to generate the "Question Permutation Table" and the "Answer Key".
- **Rendering and Output:**
 - Based on the selected output mode (such as exam, answers, or concept), the system determines whether to render correct answer markers, solution explanations, or point values.

7. Revision History

- **v0.4.1:** Bug fix for show-header and per-version-q-order.
- **v0.4.0:** Added show-header parameter to control the display of version headings.
- **v0.3.0:** Added q-breakable and a-breakable parameters to allow questions and answers to break across pages.

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- **v0.2.1:** Improved input sanity checks when using custom styles and configurations in mc-questions; fix bugs related to title formatting and question labeling.
- **v0.2.0:** Added style parameter to mc-questions for customizing output appearance.
- **v0.1.1:** Fixed critical bug in mc-questions that was accessing an outdated data structure.
- **v0.1.0:** Initial release.